



Two very different promoters of Tamil culture. (Above, left) The Christian missionary Bishop Robert Caldwell, who was commemorated in a stamp issued by India Post in 2010. (Above, right) An image based on a photograph said to be of the ardent Shaiva reformer Arumuka Navalar, who died in 1879.

This mainly Brahmin-led scholarship did not go long unchallenged. Other dissenting voices began to be heard, now representing the underclasses. They found their chief spokesman in the social activist Erode Venkata Ramasamy, affectionately known to his followers as Periyar, from the Tamil word for ‘elder’ or ‘respected person’. Periyar came from the Balija trading community in Erode and became actively involved in nationalist politics in the wake of the horrific Jallianwala Bagh massacre in Amritsar in 1919. He joined the Indian National Congress, only to resign six years later after concluding that it was intent on promoting a caste-ridden Brahminical Indo-Aryan political agenda at the expense of non-Brahmins and the Dravidian peoples of South India. He went on to found what he called the Self-Respect Movement, arguing that the concept of *suya*